

The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter



Photograph: Getty Images

Donald Trump and **Xi Jinping** exchanged warm words as the first of their summit's two days concluded. Mr Trump said it was an "honour" to be Mr Xi's friend and invited China's leader to the White House in September. Mr Xi said the countries "should be partners rather than rivals". But he earlier warned that mishandling of [Taiwan](#) could jeopardise the relationship.

James Murray was appointed Britain's new health secretary, hours after **Wes Streeting** resigned from the job having "lost confidence" in [Sir Keir Starmer](#). Mr Murray was previously chief secretary to the Treasury. Earlier **Andy Burnham**, Manchester's mayor, said he would run for parliament after a Labour Party MP resigned; he can only compete for Labour's leadership if he is an MP.

America's **Supreme Court** preserved telehealth access to **mifepristone**, [an abortion drug](#), for now, sending the case back to a lower court in Louisiana. Two conservative justices dissented. Challengers had sought to reinstate rules requiring doctors to prescribe the pill in person after a federal court in Louisiana, which has a near-total abortion ban, sided with them, prompting an appeal from drugmakers.

Iran's foreign minister, Abbas Araghchi, said ships entering the [Strait of Hormuz](#) must co-operate with his country's navy. Earlier a vessel anchored off the United Arab Emirates was reportedly seized and towed towards Iran, while a cargo ship near Oman sank after an attack. The White House said that Mr Trump and Mr Xi had agreed during talks that Hormuz “must remain open”.

Russia launched hundreds of drones and missiles at **Ukraine**, killing at least 12 people and injuring dozens more. It is the largest sustained attack since the war began: more than 1,500 drones were fired between Wednesday and Thursday, according to Volodymyr Zelensky, Ukraine's president. It comes days after [Vladimir Putin](#), Russia's president, suggested the war was “coming to a close”.

Honda reported its first annual operating loss since becoming a publicly-traded company in 1957, of ¥414.3bn (\$2.6bn). The [Japanese carmaker](#) has struggled with increased competition from China and a failed bet on electric vehicles, for which demand has fallen. The company said it would “indefinitely suspend” its plan to build an EV plant in Ontario, Canada.

Scientists in Thailand found the remains of the largest **dinosaur** from South-East Asia. *Nagatitan chaiyaphumensis*, a long-necked herbivore, belonged to the sauropods, the lineage that produced the biggest animals in Earth's history. It was probably 90 feet long and weighed around 27 tonnes—more than four the size of the African Bush elephant, the world's heftiest living land mammal.

Figure of the day: 25%, the rough proportion of Swedish students who struggle to read properly, according to the country's higher-education minister. [Read why](#) schools in Sweden are going unplugged.



Photograph: Alamy

Donald Trump visits Xi Jinping

The leaders concluded the summit's first day with a state banquet on Thursday. America's president wants [trade to be top of the agenda](#) and hopes to secure commitments from China to buy more American beans and Boeing aircraft. Each side is uneasy about export controls imposed by the other. America wants China to keep critical minerals flowing, while China wants greater access to advanced American computer chips.

But a potential dispute over [Taiwan](#) looms. Mr Xi has been pressing America to say that it "opposes" the island's independence. And although both leaders put on a show of good humour at the summit, Mr Xi earlier warned that disagreement over Taiwan could result in "confrontation, or even conflict". The temptation for Mr Trump to make concessions may grow.



Photograph: Getty Images

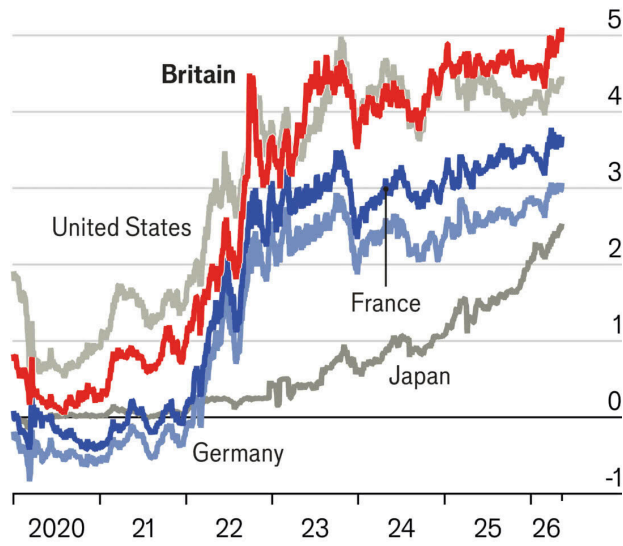
Britain's bond market bites back

Since the Iran war began yields on ten-year gilts, as British government bonds are called, have leapt from 4.2% to just over 5%. Rising energy prices are pushing up inflation—and therefore borrowing costs—everywhere. Britain is unusually vulnerable, however. It imports large amounts of energy and struggled to tame high inflation even before the crisis. Poor fiscal choices by recent governments have also led investors to demand greater compensation for holding what they see as riskier debt.

Political turmoil [continues to keep borrowing costs high](#). The prime minister, Sir Keir Starmer, is a lame duck. Wes Streeting, the health secretary, is planning a leadership challenge. Some of the prime minister's other rivals have sought to dismiss the bond market, but the danger is not abstract. If current yields were pencilled into forecasts at the next budget, debt-servicing costs in 2029-30 would be roughly £7bn (\$9.5bn) more than thought in March. That is equivalent to an extra penny in every pound on income tax.

Gilty displeasure

Ten-year government-bond yields, %



Source: LSEG Workspace



Illustration: David Simonds

India plays anxious host to the BRICS

Over the next two days India will hold what promises to be a contentious BRICS meeting. Subrahmanyam Jaishankar is hosting fellow foreign ministers from the bloc of rising non-Western economies, including Russia's Sergei Lavrov and Iran's Abbas Araghchi.

India aspires to be a bridge between the West and the rest. In convening the group, it had hoped to signal its solidarity with the “global south” even as it nurtures closer ties with America and Europe. But in fact the gathering has become a diplomatic headache.

With Iran and the United Arab Emirates attending—both of whom have joined the bloc since 2024—India is likely to be drawn into debates about [the war in the Middle East](#), which it would rather avoid. Indeed, while the BRICS gathering was meant to boost the clout of countries like India, a simultaneous meeting between Donald Trump and Xi Jinping in Beijing will only highlight how middle-ranking powers are still at the mercy of the world's two greatest.



Photograph: eyevine

Squabbling over stablecoins

America's Senate Banking Committee will mull over proposed crypto-market rules on Thursday. Bankers and crypto firms have clashed over parts of the Clarity Act, particularly those relating to [stablecoins](#), cryptocurrencies pegged to the dollar.

Last year's Genius Act set the rules for American stablecoins, but the two sides disagree over a loophole which allows crypto exchanges to pass on returns, or "yields", to holders. Banks fear this will lure savers who would otherwise deposit cash with them. The new bill tightens the ways in which exchanges can pass on yields and increases mandatory checks on customers.

Wall Street is still not satisfied. The American Bankers Association, a trade group, says the rules are not strong enough. Members of the banking committee have proposed more than 100 amendments which could be discussed at the hearing before the bill advances to the Senate floor. True clarity may be some way off.



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Thursday: Which famous physicist produced some of his most important work while employed at the Swiss patent office?

Wednesday: The departure of which baseball player in 1920 is supposed to have resulted in a long-lasting curse on the Boston Red Sox?

*The beautiful thing about learning
is nobody can take it away from
you.*

B.B. King